CALIFORNIA

The Golden State



The story begins not in California, but in the sun-bleached port city of Ensenada, Baja California, where the Pacific crashes cold against the Baja Peninsula and fishermen have long hauled in yellowtail, halibut, and corvina before dawn. It was here, sometime in the mid-20th century, that humble street vendors began tucking battered, fried fish into warm corn tortillas—dressing them with cool shredded cabbage, a squeeze of lime, and a drizzle of crema. Nobody owned the idea. It belonged to the coast itself.

For decades, the fish taco lived quietly in Ensenada's mercados and beachside stalls, beloved by locals and the occasional adventurous traveler making the dusty drive down Highway 1. Surfers, in particular, found their way there. Young men from San Diego and Los Angeles, chasing the legendary breaks at Todos Santos and Punta San José, would pull their VW vans off the road and eat standing up, dripping saltwater, paper in hand, utterly changed by what they were tasting.

It was one of those surfers—or at least someone very much like them—who would bring the fish taco north for good. In the early 1970s, a man named Ralph Rubio returned from a surfing trip to San Felipe, Baja, where he had become devoted to the fish tacos sold by a beach vendor named Carlos. Ralph reportedly spent years trying to recreate the recipe himself, and eventually convinced Carlos to share his secrets. In 1983, Ralph and his father Ray opened Rubio's Coastal Grill in Mission Bay, San Diego, and put the fish taco on the menu.

San Diego was ready for it. The city sat at the cultural crossroads of California and Baja—more Mexican in its rhythms and flavors than Los Angeles, more open to the sea than the inland valleys. The fish taco felt native there almost immediately, as natural as the salt air blowing off the bay. Lines formed. Word traveled.

By the late 1980s and into the 1990s, the fish taco had migrated up the California coast with the ease of something that had always belonged there. Taco stands in Pacific Beach, surf shacks in Malibu, beachside counters in Santa Barbara—each one put its own hand to the dish, swapping beer batter for tempura, adding mango salsa, layering in chipotle crema or pickled jalapeños. California, as it always does, made the borrowed thing its own.

No California coastal menu feels complete without one these days. But the spirit of the original remains: fresh fish, simply prepared, wrapped in something warm, eaten outside, close to the water, with the smell of the ocean not far off. Some food carries a sense of place so deeply that eating it anywhere else is still, somehow, an act of remembering where it came from.

This is one of those dishes.



FISH TACOS

From an Ensenada market stall to the surf breaks of San Diego, the fish taco is California's bright, briny gift to the beach.

Yield: 8 tacos

INGREDIENTS

FISH

- 1½ lb. white fish (like mahi-mahi, cod, halibut, or tilapia), cut into strips about 1-inch wide
- Juice of 1 lime
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying

SLAW

- 2 cups shredded cabbage (green or purple, or a mix)
- ¼ cup chopped cilantro
- 1 Tbsp lime juice
- 1 Tbsp apple cider vinegar
- Salt and pepper, to taste

CREMA

- 1 cup sour cream
- 2 Tbsp mayo
- 1 lime
- 1 tsp hot sauce
- ½ tsp garlic powder
- Salt, to taste

BATTER

- 1 cup all-purpose flour, plus more for dredging the fish
- 1 Tbsp cornstarch (for extra crispness)
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp chili powder
- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 1 cup cold beer, lager, or pilsner (or cold sparkling water)

TO ASSEMBLE

- 8 small corn tortillas
- Extra lime wedges
- Avocado slices (optional)
- Pico de gallo or diced tomatoes (optional)
- Chopped cilantro

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prep the fish*: Pat the fish very dry and cut into strips about 1-inch wide. Squeeze the lime juice over them, season lightly with salt and pepper, and set aside while you make everything else. A dry surface is the secret to batter that clings and crisps instead of sliding off.
2. *Make the slaw*: Toss the cabbage, cilantro, lime juice, vinegar, salt, and pepper together. Set aside (you can chill it for even better flavor).
3. *Mix the crema*: Whisk together the sour cream, mayo, juice of the lime, hot sauce, garlic powder, and a pinch of salt. Adjust heat or acidity to taste, then refrigerate until serving.

4. *Whisk the batter*: In a bowl, whisk together the flour, cornstarch, baking powder, chili powder, cumin, garlic powder, salt, and pepper. Pour in the cold beer and whisk just until smooth—a few small lumps are fine. Keep it cold; a cold batter hitting hot oil is what gives you that shatteringly crisp coating.
5. *Heat the oil*: Pour about 1½ inches of oil into a heavy, deep skillet or Dutch oven and heat over medium-high to 375°F (190°C). If you don't have a thermometer, a drop of batter should sizzle briskly and float to the surface right away.
6. *Fry the fish*: Spread roughly ½ cup flour on a plate. Dredge each fish strip lightly in the flour, shake off the excess, then dip into the batter, letting the extra drip off. Lower carefully into the oil, frying in batches so you don't crowd the pan. Fry, turning once, until deep golden and cooked through, 3–4 minutes total. Drain on a wire rack and season with a pinch of salt while hot. Let the oil come back up to temperature between batches.
7. *Warm the tortillas*: Toast on a dry skillet or directly over a gas flame until soft and slightly charred.
8. *Assemble the tacos*: Place a piece or two of fried fish in each tortilla, top with slaw, drizzle with crema, and finish with avocado, pico, or extra lime if desired.

NOTES & TIPS

- California-style fish tacos are a staple of West Coast beach food—light, fresh, and full of bold flavor. Inspired by Baja fish tacos but with a SoCal twist, they often feature grilled or lightly battered fish, crisp slaw, and creamy sauces—all wrapped in a warm corn tortilla.



Salt on your lips, sand on your feet, and a fish taco warm in your hand. The coast was always the kitchen.

